The Guardian

one stop english

Japan PM's solution to dire birth rate has already been rejected by young

Level 2: Intermediate – Teacher's notes

Article summary: This article describes the Japanese Prime Minister's efforts to urge families to have (more) children to pick up Japan's declining birth rate.

Time: 90 minutes

Skills: Reading, Speaking

Language focus: Vocabulary

Materials needed: One copy of the worksheet per student

1. Warmer

a. The purpose of this activity is to introduce the topic. Ask students to first read the headline and the words in the glossary and check understanding. Then ask students to discuss the questions in small groups. You could also have students predict how these questions will be answered in the article and have them skim the text very quickly to check their predictions.

2. Key words

a. Ask students to do the exercise individually and then compare their answers in pairs or small groups. Have students note that *childcare* is uncountable, and *shortage* can be both countable or uncountable. To extend this activity, you can have students investigate which other words collocate with these vocabulary items. (E.g., *demographic crisis/trends; stubbornly refuse/remain; provide an incentive; overcome obstacles; after-school childcare; receive subsidies; be reluctant to; have an ambition to; the pressures of modern life; hesitate to contact; a shortage of, etc.*)

Key:

1. *pessimist*
2. *demographic*
3. *stubbornly*
4. *incentive; incentives*
5. *obstacle; obstacles*
6. *childcare*
7. *subsidies*
8. *reluctant*
9. *ambition*
10. *pressure; pressure(s)*
11. *hesitate*
12. *shortage*

3. Comprehension check

a. Students say whether the statements are *true* or *false* and then correct the false statements.

Key:

1. *True*
2. *False. There will be a predicted 30 per cent decrease in 45 years.*
3. *False. The number continues to grow.*
4. *True*
5. *False. Subsidies for pregnancy, childbirth and childcare have failed.*
6. *True*
7. *True*
8. *False. Taro Aso did this.*
9. *True*

4. Key language

a. Students could be asked to do this exercise individually, and then compare their answers in pairs. Encourage them to support their answers by looking in the text. You can also have students add more words that they know in each column.

Key:

Upward movement	***Downward movement***	***No movement***
continue to grow	*be in decline / decline* *decrease* *sink* *suffer a fall*	*remain at*

b. Students choose three words from part A and write personalized sentences. You can walk around and offer help as they do this. Ask for volunteers to share what they wrote.

Published by Macmillan Education Ltd. © Macmillan Education Limited, 2023.

PHOTOCOPIABLE CAN BE DOWNLOADED FROM WEBSITE

The Guardian

one stop english

Japan PM's solution to dire birth rate has already been rejected by young

Level 2: Intermediate – Teacher's notes

5. Discussion

a. Allow students time to note down their ideas about each statement and encourage them to say why they agree or disagree with each one.

6. In your own words

a. The task could also be done as a homework task and students could then present their reports to the class. Encourage students to use vocabulary from the text and language to describe trends.

Published by Macmillan Education Ltd. © Macmillan Education Limited, 2023.

PHOTOCOPIABLE CAN BE DOWNLOADED FROM WEBSITE